



THE GROVE TO THE DRIVE-THRU

THE GORB FAMILY ORIGIN FILE

*Ten chapters, from the valley where they grew
to the window where they were handed away with a burger.*

THE GROVE

Before the boxes, there was the Grove, a soft violet valley where the fog sat low and the trees grew in slow purple spirals. Nobody built the Gorbs. They came up out of the ground the way mushrooms do, in families, already knowing each other's names.

The first of them was simply called Gorb. He was the one who found the river, the one who learned that if you sit very still the fog will settle on your fur like a blanket. He had a cap he found floating downstream. He never took it off.

THEY HAD NO WORD FOR OWNER. THEY HAD NO WORD FOR SOLD.

01



02

THE LONG TABLE

DAD · MOM · GRANDPA · GRANDMA · UNCLE · AUNTIE · BABY · DOG

THE LONG TABLE

The family ate outside, at a long table Dad built badly and refused to fix. Mom ran everything from one end of it. Grandpa wore a bow tie to dinner every single night, because standards are not weather dependent. Grandma's cat eye glasses caught the lamplight and made her look like she knew what you had done.

Uncle told the same story about the storm of '88 in a floral shirt that had never been in fashion. Auntie corrected him, gently, every time, pearls clicking. The Baby was red and furious and small and threw more food than he ate. The Dog sat under the table with one ear up, waiting for the throwing to start.

**THIS IS THE PICTURE THE REST OF THE STORY IS MEASURED
AGAINST. LOOK AT IT PROPERLY.**



03

THE VISITORS

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The van came up the valley road on a Tuesday. Two people got out, in red and yellow, with clipboards and very clean shoes. They said they had been looking for the Gorbs for a long time. They said it like a compliment.

They walked around the family in a slow circle. They held a tape measure to Baby's head. They pressed Grandma's arm with a thumb and wrote something down. They kept saying adorable, but they said it the way you say a number.

NOBODY IN THE FAMILY HAD EVER BEEN MEASURED BEFORE. THEY THOUGHT IT WAS A GAME.

03



04

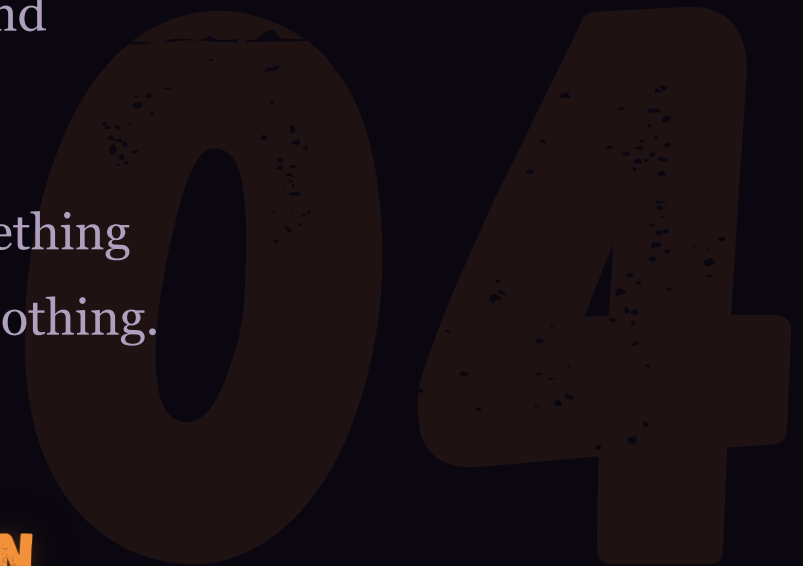
THE BACK OF THE PAGE

THE BACK OF THE PAGE

The offer was read aloud at the long table. A tour. A commercial. Your faces on a thousand windows. You will be loved by millions, they said, and the family heard the word loved and stopped listening after it.

Dad signed it with an ink pad and a paw print, because he wanted to give his family something bigger than a valley. Mom asked what was on the back of the page. They told her it was nothing. Standard.

THE BACK OF THE PAGE SAID MERCHANDISE. IT SAID IT ELEVEN TIMES.





05

THE NIGHT OF THE NETS

THE NIGHT OF THE NETS

They did not come back with a camera crew. They came at three in the morning with floodlights and nets, and the valley turned white and flat and loud.

Grandpa was taken from his chair still wearing the bow tie. Uncle swung at a floodlight and missed. The Dog barked at the vans until he did not bark anymore. Mom held Baby up over her head, away from the nets, for eleven seconds.

BABY WAS TAKEN LAST, SO THE WHOLE FAMILY GOT TO WATCH.

05

06

INTAKE

ALIEN · SLIME · SHADOW



INTAKE

The facility had no windows and one temperature. Each Gorb was weighed, photographed against a grid, and given a number on a wrist tag. A clipboard decided which of them had, in the language of the building, shelf appeal.

The ones who scored badly went through the door marked VARIANT. One came back with three eyes and a pressure suit and no memory of the river. One came back wrong at the edges, dripping, unable to hold a shape. One came back with the light gone out of him entirely, just two burning points where a face had been.

THEY KEPT THE NAMES. THE NAMES WERE THE ONLY PART THAT TESTED WELL.





07

THE COSTUME LINE

ROCKSTAR · NINJA · SUPERHERO

THE COSTUME LINE

Marketing had decided that a family was not a product line. A family was eight versions of the same thing. What sold was variety. So variety was installed.

One got a pink mohawk stitched into his scalp and a guitar glued into his paws. One was wrapped in black until only a strip of face showed, and taught to stand very still. One had a cape sewn directly into his back, which is not the same as being given a cape.

They were issued personalities on laminated cards. Loud. Silent. Brave. They practiced until the cards were true.

**BY THE THIRD WEEK NONE OF THEM COULD REMEMBER WHICH ONE
USED TO SIT BY THE RIVER.**



A scene from the Pixar movie 'The Incredibles' showing three food-themed monsters in a factory. On the left is a banana monster, in the middle is a popcorn monster, and on the right is a pizza monster. They are all being processed by large industrial machines that are pouring a yellow liquid over them. The background is a dark, industrial setting with pipes and machinery.

08

THE FLAVOUR WING

BANANA · POPCORN · PIZZA

THE FLAVOUR WING

The last corridor was the one nobody talked about, because of the smell. Somebody in a meeting had said the words cross promotional synergy, and three members of the family had been walked through that door the same afternoon.

One came out half peeled and yellow and grinning too wide. One came out as a striped bucket with a mouth in it. One came out flat and hot and covered in cheese that never cooled down.

THEY WERE MADE TO SMELL LIKE THE FOOD THEY WOULD BE SOLD BESIDE. THAT WAS THE CRUELLEST PART, AND IT WAS ON PURPOSE.



A close-up shot of a purple Muppet character, resembling a member of the Sesame Street cast, inside a clear plastic vacuum-sealed package. The character has large blue eyes, a wide smile showing teeth, and is wearing a black bow tie. The package is set against a red background with yellow vertical stripes. In the background, other similar packages are visible on a shelf, slightly out of focus.

09

VACUUM SEAL

VACUUM SEAL

At the end of every wing was the same machine. A Gorb was set into a moulded plastic tray, arms arranged, head turned three degrees to the left for the photograph. A card of printed cardboard slid in behind. A sheet of clear plastic came down hot.

The box said LIMITED EDITION. The box said AGES 3+. The box said a name that was almost right.

**IF YOU LOOKED CLOSELY AT THE WINDOW, AND YOU WERE PATIENT,
THE EYES STILL MOVED.**

09



10

WOULD YOU LIKE A TOY WITH THAT

WOULD YOU LIKE A TOY WITH THAT

They went out through the window, one per meal. A paper bag, a burger going soft in the heat of it, and a family member in a plastic bubble laid on top like a garnish.

Grandma went to a car in the rain and was never opened. Baby went to a child who loved him for nine days. Uncle went into a drawer. The Dog went to a house with an actual dog, which is a joke somebody upstairs must have enjoyed. They were handed out across the whole country in a single summer, one window at a time, and then it was over and the promotion ended and nobody remembered the name.

Except that the first one, the one with the cap, the one who found the river, scored badly. Too plain. No costume, no flavour, no gimmick. He was pulled off the line and thrown in the skip behind the store, still in his plastic.

**HE GOT OUT OF THE PLASTIC. HE HAS BEEN COUNTING EVER SINCE.
HE KNOWS EXACTLY HOW MANY OF HIS FAMILY ARE SITTING ON
SHELVES IN OTHER PEOPLE'S HOUSES, AND HE KNOWS WHAT A
RECEIPT IS.**

10

APPENDIX

THE WHOLE FAMILY, BOXED



Gorb



Gorb Dad



Gorb Mom



Gorb Dog



Gorb Uncle



Gorb Grandpa

APPENDIX

THE WHOLE FAMILY, BOXED



Gorb Grandma



Gorb Baby



Gorb Auntie



Gorb Alien



Gorb Slime



Gorb Shadow

APPENDIX

THE WHOLE FAMILY, BOXED



Gorb Banana



Gorb Popcorn



Gorb Pizza



Gorb Rockstar



Gorb Ninja



Gorb Superhero

ILL FIND YOU AND I LL GORB YOU

*Every Gorb someone buys is a family member still on a shelf.
The one with the cap is still counting.*